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2025-26 edition

princeton undergraduate society of ethics

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TELOS



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LETTER THE FROM EDITOR

Dear Reader,

We are missing an important conversation. It may be the most important conversation any society, generation, or civilization can have: the conversation about values.

We live in an age saturated with information. Every day, we are bombarded with new data and statistics. These are indispensable tools for understanding the world, but they are simply not sufficient for navigating it. Human beings require more than facts alone. We need values to orient our lives, guide our institutions, and help us answer fundamental questions about what we owe one another.

When societies lose sight of this conversation, the consequences can be profound. Our disagreements over justice, responsibility, and what the good life consists of do not vanish; they merely go unexamined.

The mission of TELOS is to help sustain and expand this conversation. We are dedicated to exploring the most pressing ethical issues of our time through the imaginative and vibrant voices of undergraduates. To further this cause, our student writers grapple with moral questions that span public policy, emerging technologies, personal identity, relationships, and culture. Ethics

and philosophy are misconceived as abstract and dry; therefore, the pieces collected here are intended to be both rigorous and accessible. We are fortunate in this endeavor to draw upon the wisdom and guidance of our faculty advisors, Peter Singer, Lara Buchak, Sara McGrath, and Gideon Rosen.

As you read, you will notice the broad ideological spectrum represented by our contributors. We encourage creativity and intellectual courage. We ask writers not only to defend their own views, but also to engage earnestly with opposing perspectives, revisit assumptions, and transcend familiar arguments. Whether addressing contemporary events or perennial philosophical questions, each contribution represents an effort to think more carefully about what matters and why.

We hope this issue invites you into that effort. More than anything else, we hope it encourages you to participate in the conversation.

Sincerely,

Joel R. Ibabao Jr.
Editor-in-Chief
TELOS

Patriotism: A Collective Affinity and Responsibility

by: Eunice Chon

The United States is a fragmented nation of multiple dichotomies. Americans are partitioned by racial tensions, cultural differences, religious schisms, and even political hyperpolarization - raising questions on how to bring unity. Unfortunately, patriotism has also become a controversial, partisan sentiment, with some conservatives viewing it “an unassailable virtue” while progressives may see “a source of mindless obedience, chauvinism, and war” (Sandel 228). Yet the same self-proclaimed, right-leaning patriots promoting America First policies and closed borders may also identify with the libertarian beliefs of consent and freedom when it comes to issues such as gun reform and COVID vaccines. Thus, I will be diverging from the unique, extreme, and contradictory American understanding of concepts such as patriotism and liberalism. In my paper, I will use MacIntyre’s definition of patriotism constituting “nothing more than a perfectly proper devotion to one’s own nation which must never be allowed to violate the constraints set by the impersonal moral standpoint” rather than an ideal that should never

be compromised nor a mindless defense of one’s nation (“Is Patriotism a Virtue?” 6). Even with a less restrictive definition, patriotism continues to have its opponents. Liberal philosophers, such as Kant and Rawls, emphasize individual preference and choice over collective devotion, and they reject non-consensual obligations that come with this devotion. Communitarians like MacIntyre, on the other hand, believe that people find meaning in who they are, which is shaped by the context and communities in which they identify, and argue for “loyalties and obligations [to others] antecedent to [individual] choice” (After Virtue). Professor Sandel writes of three kinds of moral responsibility: universal and natural duties, particular voluntary obligations, and obligations of solidarity that do not require consent (Sandel 225). Patriots, by definition, must accept the third category obligation because they believe that they have loyalty and commonality ties to their country that exceed their international obligation. Using this framework for moral obligation and a communitarian grounds, I argue the moral basis for domestic obligations over obligations to those of other countries, or patriotism for short, because (1) we have communal and moral ties to our nation as social creatures, (2) we have civic ties to our nation’s merits, accomplishments, and history as citizens, and (3) due to these attachments, we have a collective responsibility that trumps moral individualism.

First and foremost, I choose the communitarian lens because the American people have ties with other Americans in different ways and for various reasons. Whether it is through “solidarity and loyalty, historic memory, [or] religious faith,” only the explanation that communities and traditions shape our identity can possibly “make sense of a range of moral and political obligations that we commonly recognize” in our country (Sandel 220). Moral opinions on abortion may rest on some religious basis. People prize patriotism as celebrating loyalty and solidarity with the American people. When life is “more than a sequence of individual actions and episodes,” context is crucial in explaining and understanding our actions, morals, and convictions (After Virtue 316). Our ties to the United States and the American people, in particular, are our context, which MacIntyre defines as “a set of narrative his-

tories, histories both of the individuals concerned and of the settings in which they act and suffer” (After Virtue 320). By narrative histories, MacIntyre explains that people are social, storytelling creatures (Sandel 221). Because we find purpose in our relationships with others, “[we] can only answer the question ‘What am I to do?’ if [we] can answer the prior question ‘Of what story or stories do I find myself a part?’” (Sandel 221). People find themselves a part of a particular story when they identify with their community and its experiences, values, and identity. Kant’s and Rawls’ liberal notion that a person is a “freely choosing, individual [self] [without] loyalties and obligations antecedent to choice” fails to address the morality that comes from membership in a community or tradition (After Virtue 315). Not only is the word “American” an identity label, but it is also a description of the experiences and values of those who live in America. Of course, these labels should not be used as a stereotype, but despite our polarization, Americans take for granted how limited our social, cultural, and political paradigm can be. What most, if not all, of us may view as intrinsic, inherent moral ideals, such as democratic elections and freedom of speech, may not be considered so “given” or imperative in another nation. When it comes to the morality of patriotism specifically, philosopher Rousseau writes that “communal attachments and identities are necessary supplements to our universal humanity” and that patriotism is a sentiment of humanity that “intensifies fellow feeling,” which dissipates when extended over the world (Sandel 229). Neither Rousseau nor I believe that Americans should not care more about calamities in Japan. People should obviously try to be more conscious of international news and broaden their perspective and empathy for those overseas. But what Rousseau is actually saying is that limited, restrained sentiments “concentrated among fellow citizens” by loyalty and common interests are more active, which will inevitably lead to them owing “more to one another than outsiders” (Sandel 229). We should probably care more about Japan, but do opponents of patriotism care for every country as much as American patriots care for the United States? Most would not, and when human beings find morality in concentrated feelings from their relationships with their communities and affinity

groups, equal obligation would not be just either.

Patriotism does not mean a belief in American hegemony or a collective selfishness, but it does mean a peculiar regard for one’s country as well as “the particular characteristics and merits and achievements of one’s own nation” (“Is Patriotism a Virtue?” 4). As citizens of the United States, we have a civic duty to this nation as well as ties to its merits, accomplishments, and history. MacIntyre writes that “action itself has a basically historical character” because we understand ourselves and others best through narratives (After Virtue 320). The United States has a story. Our context has a story:

For the story of my life is always embedded in the story of those communities from which I derive my identity. I am born with a past; and try to cut myself off from that past, in the individualist mode, is to deform my present relationships. The possession of an historical identity and the possession of a social identity coincide (After Virtue 326).

Thompson further explains that the link between historical memory and identity demonstrates memories’ ability to motivate people (2). This motivation encourages group action but also “[predisposes] them to believe that they have obligations in respect to the past: to remember past people, to honour those who made sacrifices for the sake of the community, to carry on the work of forebears, to revenge an injustice or to undo its effects, or to fulfill a historic destiny” (Thompson 2). Historical memory is quite a frightening concept, and this paper is not justifying the atrocities committed throughout history with propaganda and demagoguery. However, historical memory should not be seen merely as something within communities of blood or psychological violence (Thompson 14). In fact, patriotic historical memory, like civic duty, is ultimately a responsibility. Civic duty does not stop at obeying traffic laws, attending jury duty, and paying taxes. It also includes showing up to the polls and galvanizing necessary change. Libertarians may ask, “If communitarians claim that we are bound by ties of solidarity or membership we have not chosen . . .

shouldn't we think of ourselves instead as capable of reflecting on the communities and traditions we inherit, deciding for ourselves which ones to affirm and which to reject?" (After Virtue 315). But I argue that one's independent acceptance or rejection of a decision or value is not mutually exclusive from patriotism and communitarianism because communitarian patriotism includes rejecting and dissenting governmental actions that are unjust. One famous example is Dr. Martin Luther King's fervent opposition to the Vietnam War because he "[loved] America." He writes that he speaks "with a passionate desire to see our beloved country stand as the moral example of the world. I speak out against this war because I am disappointed with America. And there can be no great disappointment where there is not great love" (King). Activists fight for change because they take ownership of our wrongs and have hope for what our country, society, and world can do to progress. What can possibly be more patriotic than such sacrifice and solidarity? But even with efforts to make change, we cannot dismiss the influence our nation's history and precedence continue to make in our governance and ultimately our public opinion on all kinds of issues from court packing, *Roe v. Wade*, the right to bear arms, and religious freedom. Much of our values are still shaped by the past.

However, even if we choose to denounce the past, we still must own it because we have a collective responsibility that comes before moral individualism. Historical memory can serve as an extension of this inherited civic responsibility because citizens "belong to an intergenerational partnership" and "acquire obligations because they share responsibility for the maintenance of institutions, for honouring those who made great contributions to the fulfillment of this responsibility, and for making recompense for the wrongs that were done by their institutions or by those who were given the responsibility of managing them" (Thompson 14). If Americans inherit the legacy of the past, then we inherit the costs of it too. As American citizens, we have an obligation to "remember the sacrifices that were made by their predecessors for the sake of the community, but [also] the unjust things that these predecessors did" (Thompson 14). Liberal philosophers dis-

agree, and they may say, "I may biologically be my father's son: but I cannot be held responsible for what he did unless I choose implicitly and explicitly to assume such responsibility" (After Virtue 325). Resting on the notion that we are ultimately responsible for our own actions is difficult to refute. The doctrine of moral individualism emphasizes Lockian virtues of freedom and consent (Sandel 213). An obligation to pay the costs for actions made by generations before us would infringe on one's freedom to be subject to only the laws they consent to. Kant's focus on autonomous will and reason with "Rawls's idea of a hypothetical agreement behind a veil of ignorance" both envision the moral agent as independent of personal aims and attachments, making their claims too arbitrary to determine how to live one's life (Sandel 214-215). The arbitrariness of a natural man without any social construct presents a fallacy, and leaving obligations to natural duties and voluntary, consensual ones fails to account for a collective history, experience, and responsibility that are embedded in our social structures and systems and shape who we are as both Americans and individuals (Sandel 223-224). Perhaps individually one is not personally responsible for slavery, but as an American citizen, one is obligated to contribute to the costs of that legacy. Collective apologies are one example of patriotic solidarity and membership pointing outward and "[creating] moral responsibilities for communities other than my own" (Sandel 234). Such attempts to make "amends for my country's past wrongs is one way of affirming my allegiance to it" (Sandel 234). Thus, patriotism is not about sanctifying one nation over another nor forcing citizens to conform to all decisions of the state. It is about a particular affinity and obligation one has for the community, history, and stories that shaped his identity.

Professor Sandel defines patriotic pride as a "sense of belonging to a community extended across time" (235). This pride requires a sense of responsibility for carrying a nation's "story into the present" and facing the "moral burdens that come along with it" (Sandel 235). Picking and choosing between what pieces of our nation's legacy to identify with and which parts to ignore is not only unjust, but it is unpatriotic. For instance, true patriots would

not believe that critical race theory would teach children to hate America. Rather, they would take ownership of the history that was left ignored for too long in our nation's education system and foster strong democratic practices such as healthy discourse, possibly dissent, and unity as a collective nation. Basing justice on a neutral system of independent agents - every man for himself - does not encapsulate how human beings gravitate towards community, shared identity, and collective experiences. These social contexts play a large role in shaping not only who we are but also what we ought to do and how we ought to live. Using this communitarian argument, I argue that patriotism encompasses an important solidarity obligation that is moral and better represents how human beings act as moral agents. Perhaps with the development of online, global communications technologies, one day, our communities and affinity groups will be based across country lines. But until then, the nation and the people we come from shape much of our morals, identities, and responsibilities.

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Why Death is Bad: Expanding the Deprivation Account

By: Cristian Diaz



Let us stipulate that the death of the body is the end of conscious existence and that there is, as a matter of fact, no afterlife to look forward to. Yet this raises an enduring question: if death marks the absence of conscious experience, in what sense can it be bad for the one who dies? About two millennia ago, Epicurus argued that death cannot harm us, since “where we are, death is not, and where death is, we are not.” Against this, Thomas Nagel and Shelly Kagan defend the Deprivation Account, which argues that death is bad not because of any painful experience of dying, but because it deprives us of the intrinsic goods we would have continued to enjoy had we remained alive.

In *Mortal Questions*, Nagel contends that “if death is an evil, it is the loss of life, rather than the state of being dead or of nonexistence, which is objectionable” (Nagel 2). He claimed that what makes death bad is its capacity to strip us of goods such as perception, desire, activity, and thought. Similarly, in *Death*, Kagan argues that “death is bad because it deprives me of the good things in life” (Kagan 205). These goods include meaningful work, loving relationships, and pleasurable experiences. Together, Nagel and Kagan frame death’s badness as a robbery of value.

Deprivationism’s contention is that certain human activities and capacities render death bad: having a laugh, finishing a book, listening to a song, eating a meal, falling in love. Although I agree that death is bad, I argue that death is bad twofold: first because it deprives us of positive goods, and secondly because it deprives us of instrumental negative events; experiences whose troublesomeness enables many of the goods that make life valuable.

Death cannot be bad solely because we are deprived of positive goods, because life is not composed solely of them. Life is, to varying degrees, distasteful, strenuous, and sacrificial. I call these “negative events.” They have instrumental value, though not reliably so. They serve as means to greater ends. Consider how they interplay with the goods Nagel and Kagan describe.

Would having a laugh be half as enjoyable without

the stresses that draw your attention? Or would reading a book be as gratifying without the struggle of unfamiliar prose? These goods would be less significant if you hadn't earned, through your share of trouble, the joy they provide.

Not all suffering is purposeful. Death is categorically bad because our troubles often feel purposeless, even when they are not; but those negative events that are not purposeless require us to view them as instrumentally positive. Much of what is called purposeless suffering is, in my view, preventable suffering that results from human failings, negligence, or circumstance.

History is no stranger to negative events; they often function as an undercurrent of progress. Human potential is preserved in our ability to overcome them. It is the promise that our potentials may flourish which inclines us to be well to ourselves and others. Secondly, the willingness to be changed by a negative event is integral to meaning-making and choosing dignity over harm. Thirdly, the knowledge of death as a forthcoming certainty instrumentalizes suffering and allows for the reconciliation of a negative event with the goods that make death bad.

Take hunger. At its healthiest, hunger is a reminder to sate ourselves so that we remain healthy. At its worst, it is a biological alarm insisting we feed ourselves before our bodies fail. Hunger is not a good experience, and famine does not discriminate. Yet hunger is an experience without which we would be incapable of enjoying food in any meaningful way. Beyond everyday consumption, what desire would someone have to feed their family if not for the satisfaction of relieving hunger? We sympathize with the starving because we are subject to the same pains.

Consider the things created from utilizing hunger: restaurants, fine dining, grocery stores, homemade delicacies. Hunger is purposive insofar as we treat it as instrumental. Without it, we could not qualify enjoying a meal as a positive good. Thus, a Deprivationist should not say that death is bad solely because of the goods we are deprived of, because many

goods depend on instrumental negative events.

What of purposeless suffering? Much of it is indeed suffering without instrumentality. I don't disagree, but much is preventable moral, social, or interpersonal suffering. Such suffering is best categorized threefold. Firstly, blameworthy actions that improve nothing for anyone are purposeless and preventable. Secondly, innocence deprived because of a personal decision is also purposeless and preventable. Thirdly, maladaptive situating; new environments causing unexpected suffering, is likewise purposeless and preventable. Purposeless suffering arises from the moral position of agents, the guilt of those who caused harm, the innocence of those who endured it, and the circumstances that brought them together. Its preventability lies not in imagining some hidden use for it, but in refusing to treat death, irrecoverable as it is, as its solution; for death forecloses the possibility of future goods, whereas living on keeps that possibility open.

With purposeless suffering, one may and often ought to try living not merely in spite of it, but because of it. This is especially true of ills beyond preventability like Alzheimer's, ALS, and Huntington's. These are not preventable, yet the existence of instrumental negative events is sufficient to render death bad because they occur more frequently. Thus, while much human-made purposeless suffering is preventable, non-preventable purposeless suffering is non-instrumental. Nevertheless, it doesn't negate the Deprivation Account but reminds us why we should strive to minimize non-preventable purposeless suffering.

This is also the case for Nagel's "mind-dependent" goods such as perception, desire, activity, and thought. You can see weather and consider it beautiful because you think it so. You can perceive a horse galloping and think it incredible because you desire to ride it. But it is atypical to see a storm and think it wonderful, or to see a horse being tamed and wish to bond with it. It is not typical for people to see a negative event and persist in the conviction to manufacture a positive good from it. But it is not impossible, and we ought to engender this attitude if we're to see life and death in their totality.

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To see life and death in their totality requires resisting the inference that death's badness makes immortality good. It does not. Death's badness reveals that life's goods depend on the finitude that gives negative events their meaning. Without that finitude, their instrumental force dissipates entirely. Thus, immortality is not good merely because death is categorically bad.

Thus, the Deprivation Account remains compelling, but it gains nuance when we consider that the goods of life extend beyond positive goods. The goods that make death bad often emerge from negative events, and when instrumentalized, heighten our appreciation of conscious existence by homing in on death's categorical badness. From this vantage point, the prevalent badness of life becomes a pathway to its preciousness, making death's deprivation all the more poignant.

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The Rhythm of Responsibility: The Ethics of Feeling

by: Pierre du Plessis



The bass hit first, its low, warm, physical feel thumping me alive at a Black Coffee concert on a farm in South Africa. As I moved toward the front, I felt the deep melodic notes resonate in my chest, the vibration pulling my body into motion. Around me, people held up their phones: filmed, posed, posted. I felt disappointed, disheartened. As a music lover, I recognized the facade of attendance without presence. I asked myself: what does it mean to be “present” in a musical moment? What moral work does being part of a crowd, of a rhythm, perform? And what responsibility do we hold when attendance becomes mere spectatorship?

In our modern concert culture, this matters. Many shows today look like rituals of display rather than participation. At one recent Keinemusik event, reviewers observed: “Keinemusik fans take videos more than they dance ... But also, Keinemusik themselves are to blame for the lack of solid dance-floor vibes – they could have requested no phones, and didn’t.”¹ Phones become barriers between us and the music, between us and each other. The aesthetic of the moment shifts from feeling the music to showing the music.

Contrast these big events with more intimate encounters of rhythm. I love to seek out a piano in an airport terminal and play. Strangers pause. Smiles cross unfamiliar faces. In those few minutes we become a collective: one body listening, one body producing. The boundary between musician and audience blurs.

I turn to a familiar concept in sociology: Émile Durkheim’s notion of collective effervescence² – that electric, unifying energy that flows when individuals act in synchrony, sharing the same thoughts or movements in a group ritual. Modern research shows this phenomenon correlates with increased empathy, a sense of belonging and self-transcendent values. Music, in the context of collective effervescence, creates emotional resonance, rhythmic synchronisation and common identity through non-verbal communication and expression.

In one of my courses this semester we read an

article from the Washington Post about “Budots,” a TikTok-popular Filipino genre created by DJ Love in Davao, Philippines. DJ Love samples traffic, children, and market sounds and uses music to redirect youth away from drugs and crime and toward dancing. In this case, music becomes social intervention; collective engagement becomes ethical and communal practice.

Philosophically, this suggests that music is more than entertainment: it is a moral act of attunement to shared humanity. Emmanuel Levinas supports this idea with the view that the encounter with the Other calls us into responsibility. Music extends this call across the crowd. For Aristotle, communal activity is essential to flourishing and human virtue. If we treat music merely as display, we reduce its ethical promise of binding us together.

Public spaces of listening – whether a Japanese park piano gathering or a summer silent-disco on Cape Town’s beaches – make the practice visible and heard. Silent discos, especially, play with uniformity of experience: each participant hears the same beat, moves in sync, with no performer to film.

In the end, my Black Coffee memory returns: I felt the bass vibrating through me, alive, moving, connected. That choice isn’t trivial: it is ethical. Music invites us into communion; it reminds us that we are not solitary.

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On The Case For A Service Career

by: Joel Ibabao



In an age that celebrates self-fulfillment, Norman Care offered an ethic as austere as it is uncommon. In “Career Choice,” Care highlights a central moral problem in deciding a vocation: how a reasonably competent individual should balance self-realization and service to others. Care asserts that, in light of the dire conditions faced by the worst-off in the world, a reasonably competent person ought to choose a career of service. I will outline his argument and then raise three objections: about the comparative effectiveness of service careers, the concept of intergenerational stewardship, and its extreme demandingness. I then develop a perspective called the Fairness Outlook, whereby obligations to alleviate suffering and inequality are collective. On this view, each person is responsible for a fair share of the work of reducing suffering, not for maximizing the total good alone. That standard, I argue, can meet all three objections.

First, it is essential to clarify what self-actualization and service mean in the context of careers. A self-realizing career fosters a person’s intellectual, creative, or personal growth and fulfillment. A service career directly addresses the destitution and gross disparities that impede others’ ability to self-actualize, for example, work in the “distribution of healthcare or the administration of an international human-rights organization” (Care 1984, 283). It is crucial to clarify that the task of enabling more people to self-actualize includes ensuring substantive access to resources such as shelter, education, and medical care, such that everyone enjoys a decent standard of life.

Care’s argument takes the form of a moral matrix that evaluates three distinct moral outlooks—separate-life individualism, shared-fate individualism, and liberal individualism—across three theoretical social conditions or “worlds.” This heuristic enables him to illustrate the implications of each outlook governing career choice. It is both a thought experiment and a stress test: by varying the starting assumptions, Care exposes which moral view ultimately holds up under the conditions of the real world.

I shall begin by defining each of the three outlooks.

The first outlook is separate-life individualism: persons are morally separate agents. Human beings can form communities and bind themselves through contracts. Still, they enter the world as distinct individuals whose lives, in the final analysis, are their own to organize and lead. On this view, self-realization and personal projects have presumptive priority; service to others is admirable but not required. The second outlook is shared-fate individualism, the view that one's life is inextricably linked with others—that “fate is shared”—and that all persons belong to a global moral community in which everyone's interests and well-being count equally. By virtue of being part of the global community, we owe certain obligations to one another. This is more applicable now more than ever, given the unprecedented scale of global interconnection through technology, diplomacy, and trade. The third outlook is liberal individualism, which attempts a middle course: it may promote self-realization, service, or a combination of both, depending on the circumstances (Care 1984, 293-294).

I will reconstruct the three theoretical worlds Care outlines and indicate what each outlook above would recommend. In the first case, all human beings are positioned to realize themselves. This situation, in which poverty and severe inequality are absent, is the simplest: one should choose the vocation that best promotes self-realization. In the second case, not everyone can realize themselves, but an institutional scheme works reasonably well to expand opportunities to do so. Liberal welfare states, for instance, offer public education, health-care, and unemployment benefits as social safety nets that prevent people from falling into poverty. Care also asks us to treat all human beings as equal moral persons; therefore, this hypothetical envisions a world community that collaborates to secure everyone's fundamental needs. In such a world, separate life individualism still requires no attention beyond self-realization, since it recognizes no intrinsic, binding, or significant community membership beyond voluntary agreements. By contrast, shared fate individualism and liberal individualism endorse a concept of “self-realization cum service to others.” This means one should pursue a career that combines self-realization with service (Care 1984,

290).

In the final scenario, which Care believes resembles the real world, many people cannot realize themselves, and there is no comprehensive institutional scheme or even an effective patchwork in place that operates toward that end. Separate life individualism retains the same recommendation as before. This view need not express egoism or deny equal worth; this view can affirm that all lives have equal value while insisting that each life is separate and that the value of one is independent of facts about others. Care argues this stance is too callous because by denying the inherent interconnectedness of human life, it permits extraordinary indifference and leaves urgent relief to the capriciousness of whatever “special reasons” competent individuals happen to have. That leaves shared fate individualism and liberal individualism as viable options. Liberal individualism permits, but does not require, sacrificing self-realization for the sake of service to others. Shared fate individualism suggests relinquishing self-realization when doing so would alleviate suffering and advance the world toward greater equality in people's capacity for self-actualization (Care 1984, 291 - 294).

Care acknowledges that either path carries real risks. Embracing shared fate individualism can produce acute frustration at the loss of self-realization. However, he argues that this need not be inescapable: people can cultivate different talents and capacities than those a self-realization-centered career would develop, and over time, come to find genuine satisfaction in them; they may eventually release the initial regret about foregoing self-realization. On the other hand, the compromise that liberal individualism permits may be too modest to secure tangible and lasting progress toward universal self-realization. The sheer scale of the problem may necessitate multiple generations of dedicated individuals to forgo self-realization for the sake of service. He concedes that if a reasonable number of people can realize themselves or if an institutional scheme is moving effectively toward that goal, letting service prevail over self-actualization may indeed be too demanding. However, he reminds us that neither condition holds in the real world; quite the opposite,

in fact, and he insists that morality may require such demanding obligations in circumstances as dire as our own. Therefore, people should pursue careers of service rather than self-actualization (Care 1984, 297 - 298).

My first objection concerns the comparative effectiveness of a service career. Consider a reasonably competent individual choosing between a high-paying job in a for-profit firm that enables self-actualization and a lower-paying job in a nonprofit. The for-profit path allows for larger financial donations, whereas the nonprofit path enables direct engagement with a worthy cause and a more tangible sense of one's own altruism. Care would favor the nonprofit since it is explicitly a service role. However, suppose Care is correct that the aim is to reduce inequality in people's ability to self-actualize and lift them out of destitution. In that case, it may be more effective for a reasonably competent individual to pursue a self-realizationist career that provides a stable salary to donate, rather than accepting a low-paying service position. In response, Care would question whether most or even much high-paying for-profit work produces a net positive effect. Even if a significant portion of one's salary is donated to alleviate poverty, the career itself may occasionally engender and perpetuate the very injustices those donations aim to address. For example, consider a corporate lawyer defending exploitative labor practices, or a financial executive whose firm profits from speculative instruments that destabilize developing economies. In such cases, the social harm generated by one's self-realizationist occupation could outweigh the benefits of their philanthropy. However, I would argue that if a reasonably competent individual did not take the self-realizationist high-paying job, someone else would almost certainly do so. That person might not donate at all. For-profit roles exist in competitive labour markets where others quickly fill vacancies with similar skills but different motivations. The harm enacted by the firm would therefore occur irrespective of who occupies the position. The key difference is whether the surplus generated by that role is redirected toward reducing inequality through charitable giving. In response, Care may argue that what he really meant by a service ca-

reer was a career chosen on the basis of desiring to improve the material conditions of the worst off, not necessarily a career whose job description explicitly entails service. In line with our earlier reasoning, an agent may choose a high-paying career not because they are passionate about it, but because they want to use its salary in the service of a noble cause; this counts as a reasonably effective service career, thereby weakening my objection.

The second objection concerns intergenerational stewardship, the idea that we should attend not only to the suffering of the present generation but also to that of future generations. If Care holds that all human interests count equally regardless of location, parity should extend across time as well. Care implicitly assumes that service careers are often best positioned to address urgent needs, such as famine relief or assistance following natural disasters. Projects without an immediate humanitarian connection, therefore, appear wasteful to Care, even if they advance an individual's self-actualization. Nevertheless, self-realizationist careers can ultimately alleviate inequality and suffering in ways that service careers cannot, especially when considering a long-term perspective. Consider Isaac Newton, who might have directed his prodigious talents toward the pressing welfare problems of his day, but instead vehemently pursued intellectual passions for their own sake. By articulating the laws of gravitation and motion, he laid the intellectual foundations for later technologies that reduced suffering on an unimaginable scale. Newtonian mechanics enabled accurate celestial navigation, which in turn allowed ships to calculate longitude and predict tides. Safer and faster voyages stabilized food supplies by transporting grain and other essential goods to regions of scarcity, thereby lowering the cost of goods and reducing famines caused by local crop failures. Consider Gregor Mendel whose curiosity led him to cross-breed pea plants. His efforts to understand how traits were inherited later allowed advances such as hybrid crops resistant to disease and insulin production through genetically engineered bacteria. Countless historical precedents demonstrate that, to honor intergenerational equity, at least some people should be permitted to pursue self-realizationist careers, as such work can indirectly but significantly

alleviate the suffering of future generations.

The third objection is that shared life individualism imposes moral demands that are unrealistic for most people and therefore violates the “ought implies can” principle, which states that moral obligations presuppose the ability to fulfill them. For example, individuals in service careers may burn out and become unable to sustain the motivation necessary for productivity, or find that the intensity of their vocation begins to diminish the quality of their lives outside of work. This risk is less likely in a self-actualising career, where passion uniquely summons the necessary inner strength and perseverance in the face of setbacks or intense hours. Care may reply that the objection presupposes that a reasonably competent person cannot manage rest, boundaries, and workload to sustain service over the long term. He would also sympathize with the friction introduced into countless lives by shared life individualism, but maintain that the substantial expected reduction in suffering justifies the trade-off at least under dire circumstances like our own. Consider the following two agents: Agent A is reasonably competent and has satisfied physiological, safety, social, and esteem needs, but has not yet achieved self-actualization. Agent B lacks necessities such as clothing, clean water, or shelter. If A forgoes some self-actualization to pursue a career that secures B’s basic needs, aggregate welfare increases. The principle of diminishing marginal utility clarifies this outcome: a slight reduction in A’s higher-order fulfillment produces a disproportionately large gain in B’s baseline well-being.

I now introduce an original moral attitude that I call the Fairness Outlook, which adequately addresses the three objections to Care’s view. Notice that Care’s argument is maximalist, which means an agent is required to select the vocation that most reduces suffering and inequality among the worst off. This produces two weaknesses. It blurs the boundary between what is morally required and what is supererogatory, and it treats a person’s career choice as if it were made in isolation from everyone else. As I shall show, these present less intractable difficulties for the Fairness Outlook.

To start, we should define the entailments of the Fairness Outlook. It rejects Care’s maximalist orientation and its consequent focus on isolated individual responsibility. Our duties to alleviate misery and promote human flourishing are collective. This entails that each person ought to contribute, and the measure of any one person’s duty is what that person would be required to do if everyone else also did their part. In my view, no individual is required to organize their professional life around making the world as good as it possibly can be; however, this is still permitted. Note also that although one’s fair share is found by estimating the portion of the collective task that would fall to that person under universal cooperation, we are required to continue to meet that standard even if others fail to do theirs.

First, the Fairness Outlook answers the objection about comparative effectiveness. Doing one’s fair share can involve periods of service work and periods of self-realization within the same lifetime. In this way, a person can alternate between different occupations depending on the available evidence about which ones are more effective in reducing inequality and destitution worldwide. Additionally, the Fairness Outlook allows one to reasonably limit one’s efforts to their local or immediate community, such as tutoring incarcerated learners through a nearby prison education program or mentoring recently resettled families through the local library’s ESL program. Instead of the ambitious global perspective that Care endorses, the Fairness Outlook holds that if each person addressed the pressing problems within their own community, the broader landscape would begin to right itself. Alternatively, a maximalist outlook would push a person to devote themselves exclusively to a service career, which may be too broad or generalized. By limiting the geographic scope of our responsibilities, individuals reduce the risk of being immobilized by competing considerations.

Second, the Fairness Outlook adequately addresses the objection regarding intergenerational equity. One’s fair share can evolve in response to what the current or previous generation has achieved or failed to achieve. Each generation can identify a bundle of issues it is best positioned to address,

leaving other problems to successors who may have better tools, knowledge, or institutions. In this way, each generation does its fair share over time. For example, the 1960s and 1970s generation focused on advancing civil rights and women's equality. Today, our generation faces the Pandora's box of artificial intelligence, whose power to automate, manipulate, and surveil could either deepen inequality or redefine human flourishing. Care may respond that, on this view, if a previous generation is negligent, it exacts more stringent demands on the career choices of people today. Moreover, repeated ineffectiveness of past generations in solving their problems may result in draconian demands that people would reject as unfair. No one chooses when they're born, but the Fairness Outlook determines how stringent one's obligations governing career choice are.

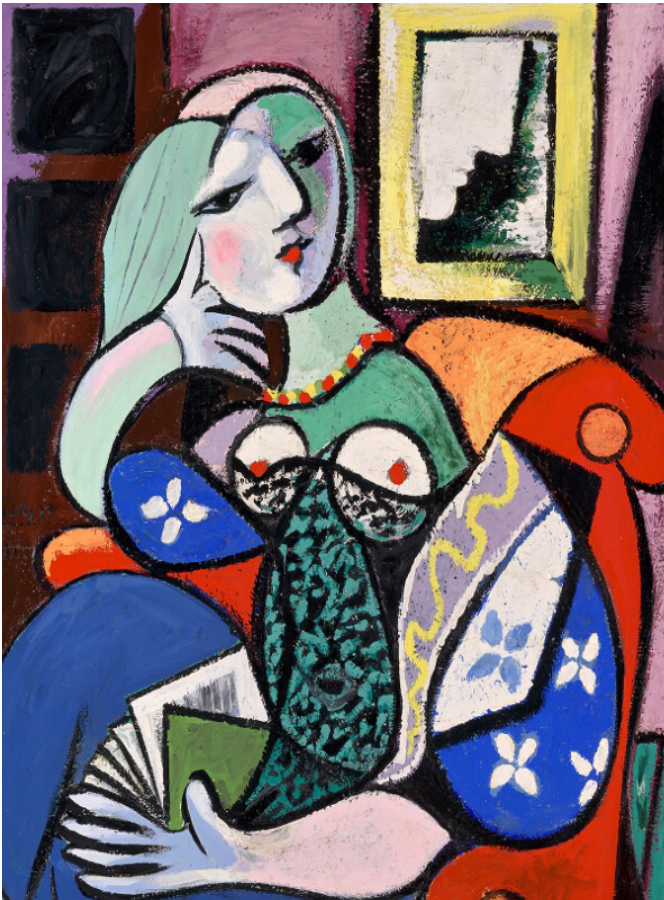
Lastly, it undermines the demandingness objection because it transforms moral duty from an impossible ideal into a livable guide. A person fulfills their responsibility not by depleting their psychological and emotional reserves in pursuit of the greatest good, but by acting in ways they could reasonably expect everyone else to act in similar circumstances. One comment Care may make regarding my theory is that it remains empirically challenging to accurately measure one's fair share, given the complexity of individuals' psychology, capacities, and competing interests. However, even if that is true, it remains a far less onerous task than determining which career would be most effective in reducing inequality and poverty worldwide.

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Shaping Society, or Shaped by Society?

by: Grace Im



We are all a mosaic of our experiences. And what can be said to provide us with more experiences than the society in which we live? But as much as we are beneficiaries of its resources, we are also limited by the scope of that which is granted to us. Are we truly choosing our path amidst society, or are we condemned to abide by it? The question applies to all who exist within a society, but there is a subset of this group that warrants special consideration.

Throughout the course of modern history, the role of women in society has undergone drastic changes—having been said to originate from man's rib to being considered property to shaping society as mothers, homemakers, and workers.

This metamorphosis might already seem all-encompassing, but I wonder whether there is a final stage to this evolution that is yet unreachable: to be made simply woman—woman without appositives. For too long, society has molded, contorted, compressed, and compacted the shape of Woman to fit its needs. Granted, society might be said to have this effect on all its constituents, but most will find it hard to deny that its stipulations on the female sex are particularly striking.

The question of gender inequality, especially with regards to societal norms, is not a new topic. If we acknowledge that certain societal limitations exist such that it incapacitates the ability of women to be free, the question then becomes: to what extent do women choose their path—and by extension, their identity?

A recent reading of Edith Wharton's *The House of Mirth* urged me to question the level of agency one has amidst society. In the novel, the young protagonist Lily Bart strives to fit into the high society of New York City in the 1890's. Destitute by its financial standards, she is always dependent on a patron, whether it be her aunt or a wealthy man.

From the onset, women's roles and expectations in Lily's society are made clear. They are raised, taught, their very existence immolated to leave nothing but transient beauty. And Lily participates in this game

of Society not as the player but as the piece—her power existing only through her ability to move within rules she did not make. It is then not so remarkable that a chess piece should not know life beyond the chessboard.

But at every turn where she might have captured victory—where a “checkmate” could mean financial stability or social acceptance—Lily’s affection for a young bachelor immobilizes her. Perpetuated in a limbo between the values that society imputes and one of honest love, her life is unable to move forward in any one direction.

The practical and only reality that Lily operated under was that she was a beautiful, poor young woman. She needed money and, therefore, a husband. The bachelor appreciates and relishes the comforts of wealth but despises the pursuit of it. Lily shares this sentiment to some degree, but unlike him, she does not have the luxury to condemn the hand that feeds her. It is only in privilege that one can ponder the morality of the benefactor.

At the novel’s end, Lily dies, alone and impecunious. She does, however, seemingly redeem her dignity by repaying the debt owed to a patron. In doing so, is she demonstrating moral integrity, naive idealism, noble self-sacrifice, or merely fulfilling an inevitable fate?

What choice did she truly have?

She was exquisitely capable in the roles she had been trained to inhabit, and it was precisely this cultivated capability that shackled her to society. As Rousseau said, “man is born free, and everywhere he is in chains.” In her inability to escape, Lily represents not only herself, but the lives of the women of her time, faintly veiled by the chimera of choice. Perhaps the novel’s denouement borders the extreme, but by rejecting society’s values, is one not subjected to relegation—to social death?

One might argue that this quandary is obsolete; after all, women are no longer dependent on marriage as a means of financial capability. But everywhere—and at every time period—women are faced with paradox. Women should look attractive and

youthful, but never vain or self-obsessed; women should be independent and ambitious, but always gentle, selfless, and maternal; women should be confident and assertive, but never outspoken or domineering; women should embrace their sexuality but also strive for modesty, and both only in ways that Society deems aesthetic. Women can choose any path, but any path chosen invites unbounded judgment: stay-at-home moms are wasting potential, career women are neglecting family, child-free women are selfish, traditional women are oppressed, and feminists are angry.

In the way that Hermann Hesse explores the search for identity in novels like *Peter Camenzind* and Dostoevsky probes the complexities of faith and morality in *The Brothers Karamazov*, Wharton examines human fragility through the lens of womanhood. Each author, in their own way, asks what it means to exist as both an individual and a social being.

In some ways, it is a good thing that society limits our choices and that we are not in a state of nature with unbridled chaos. Yet even if we sought to escape its constraints, could we really leave our world behind for Thoreau’s *Walden Pond*, with nothing but the *Bhagavad Gita* and the *Iliad* to keep us company? I think not. As Aristotle said, man is a political animal, and isolation is contrary to human essence.

So then how do we reconcile our own humanity with the identity that society imputes upon us?

Hesse’s *Peter Camenzind* has been described as portraying “the individual’s search for a unique spiritual and physical identity amidst the backdrops of nature and modern civilization.” At one point or another, everyone undertakes this search—whether through faith, ambition, intellect, or despair. As society evolves, the identity of women evolves with it. We mold, contour, and redefine ourselves within the boundaries of what is offered to us. As Sartre suggested, existence may precede essence, but perhaps essence can only emerge in dialogue with society.

I don’t mean to discourage anyone from doubting

free will, or for anyone to walk away with a sense of insignificance. The point is not to surrender all responsibility for who we are to society, but to acknowledge its presence and contextualize our lives within it; to question what it means to be a woman but also allow yourself grace when you find extrinsic labels confronting you.

Only then, maybe we will find that when judging others—and ourselves—the world is not such a solipsistic shade of black and white. When we see ourselves as more than an alienated and self-reliant entity, we can recognize the hues around us that color our lives—and begin to create our own unique blend.

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Political Absurdity in our Times

by: Noah James Kubiak



We, as a human race, face vast and difficult issues in our daily lives. Climate change, social and economic inequalities, political unrest, famine and water shortages, disease; one could go on. These are also issues that have no singular objective solution, and the potential solutions are complex, arduous, and require extensive global restructuring. How ought one respond to these crises? We collectively demand change and yet one cannot help feeling that the efforts are futile. We recycle and still we find an ocean filled with plastic. We protest and still we find corruption in our governments. We donate and still we find that every mouth we feed, two more are still hungry.

French writer and philosopher, Albert Camus, grappled with a similar tension in the wake of World War II, confronting the prevailing nihilistic thought and moral uncertainty of the time. In his essay *The Myth of Sisyphus*, he seeks to solve the “one truly serious philosophical problem”: that being suicide or, more specifically, whether suicide is required with the realization of the meaningless and absurdity of the universe. He defines his concept of the “absurd” or the “absurd condition”; we long for understanding, “an appetite for the absolute” and “for unity.” In return we meet “the impossibility of constituting the world as a unity.” The absurd does not lie in man (that is to say, it is not an essential property of our existence), nor does it lie in the world, as individual properties. Rather, the absurd is a relationship— or more precisely, a confrontation. There is a disproportion between the intention of man and the bare reality he will encounter. The absurd is a being’s search for an ultimate meaning within the inherent meaningless of the universe.

It can be said that this is exactly what is going on in our political climate today. As individuals, we experience this tension when we act to solve or aid with these global-scale issues. We are aware of the importance and level of catastrophe these issues can bring, while we are also aware of our impotence. Camus focuses on individual meaning within our lives and offers his solution to that issue, and I believe we should utilize a similar framework to resolve this

tension. For now, I'll call this extension the "political absurd."

After recognizing the notion of the absurd, Camus moves to examine what past philosophers, such as Lev Chestov, Søren Kierkegaard, and Edmund Husserl (among others), have done to solve the issue. He deems them all guilty of a certain crime, one he calls "philosophical suicide." These philosophers reach conclusions that contradict the original absurd condition that Camus promoted. In the case of Kierkegaard and Chestov, they moved away from reason and turned towards God, while Husserl tried to elevate reason, forming an abstract God. He accuses them of taking 'leaps of faith.' They claim to have knowledge of things which go beyond rationality, i.e., belief based solely on faith (not strictly in the religious sense). Kierkegaard and Chestov, in turning towards God, have now arrived at an 'ultimate truth,' dissolving the absurd. Husserl, with his phenomenology, is too Platonic for Camus, trying to find explanations and rationality within our experiences of the world. In this way, he too constructs some ultimate truth; hence, dissolving the absurd. Camus cannot accept these leaps; the absurd is fundamental to the human condition, and must therefore be preserved. When following the absurd to its conclusions, Camus admits that "that struggle implies a total absence of hope (which has nothing to do with despair), a continual rejection (which must not be confused with renunciation), and a conscious dissatisfaction (which must not be compared to immature unrest)."

I believe we see similar "leaps" when discussing the "political absurd." We are often given small moral comforts when it comes to our actions: "every action counts," "just do what you can," etc. Sure, this may be helpful for soothing our anxiety about our helplessness. But these small justifications don't resolve the actual tension at hand. The political absurd is not just a psychological state we can lift ourselves out of. It is a structural condition of living in our modern world. Camus wants to remain lucid and persistent in living with the absurd. So, I too want to know how to remain persistent in the face of our political world.

However, to stop acting altogether is not an option, just as suicide is not an option for Camus. To commit suicide is to deny the absurd; "Suicide, like the leap, is acceptance at its extreme," he states. But the absurd cannot solely be accepted; it must be confronted and kept alive. So to refuse to act, to be faced with large scale issues and do nothing, is to commit suicide. To not act is to negate one of the conditions of the political absurd. "One of the only coherent philosophical positions is thus revolt," Camus announces. Yes, we cannot have hope that our small actions will solve large-scale issues, but that is no reason to despair. It's necessary to be continuously dissatisfied. "That revolt is the certainly of a crushing fate, without the resignation that ought to accompany it." Just as this revolt gives life its value, it gives our actions value as well.

Where does this leave us? When facing political absurdity, it is necessary to recognize our own futility and live with it. I am not going to solve global warming by recycling and turning off the lights before I leave. I am not going to solve government corruption and stop wars by protesting. To use small moral comforts does not resolve this truth. But to resign to inaction denies the tension altogether. It denies that these issues are ones that exist and need to be solved in the first place. So, all that is left is to revolt. Revolting is to be faced with these catastrophes and act despite its seeming futility. To live with the political absurd that constitutes our modern world, we need to change our thinking from "How can I make a difference?" to "How can I act authentically, whilst knowing that I cannot?"

As Camus says, this will restore "majesty to that life." You must take pride in your actions and accept the absurdity of our world.

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The Genocide of the Backyard Rats

by: Abraham Lafaye-Torres



When I was 12. I was forced by my father to wipe out a brood of rats. I have to admit I saw myself as a conqueror over these animals. The process of setting the traps and poison near where they ran at night, I felt, was a testament to my cleverness, human reason triumphs easily over the pests.

That was, until the next day.

It was cold that morning in my backyard in Miami, Florida, or at least that's how I remember it. I had to wake up early before we let the dogs out to eat, to make sure any corpses were thrown away before they might accidentally ingest the poison.

Almost a dozen rats lay under the tree they called home the previous night. From the mother, to the adolescents, down to even the smallest infant, there they lay, together. The adolescents were the sort of rats you'd see in pictures. They had passed on in the night, stiff as taxidermy.

I carried a plastic garbage bag to place them, hardly a grave, but for some reason unknown to me, it was important to me to handle them with care –this I remember well.

Some were twitching, staring up at me as I picked them up with a shovel and carefully placed them into the bag. Too far gone to move, yet I did not see anger in their eyes, biased as I may be, it was fear. I cried.

There was one left I thought, and she was big, the kind of rat you'd only see in this situation. A Brood Mother, she was, at least double the largest ones I'd seen up until this point and because of her size, she was not only alive, but alert. Her eyes looked up at me awake and aware. She twitched as I approached, yet unlike the others I witnessed her attempts at escape.

She'd never let me get this close if she had any strength. I lifted her with the shovel I used to lift the others and laid her into the bag.

I thought that was all of them, yet there was one

more. A nursing babe had passed quickly underneath his mother.

Like his family, the little rat that knew nothing but the warmth of his mother, fell on top of her in the bag. Unaware that the reason he died was because he and his family were...well, annoying.

I wondered about that last bit, being told we had good reason to kill the poor things. They left droppings in the yard and drove the dogs wild at night. Dirty and dangerous, I believed. It seemed to me these reasons were weightless when I looked upon the babe, face down in the grass.

I found no real reason to hate these animals aside from how I was taught to view rats.

We saw them as carriers of disease but that baby was nothing of the sort at that moment. It was a life that didn't get the chance to live because of me.

So why did I feel it was wrong? Well, we killed these beings for an unjust reason, not because they were food but simply because they were dirty. Perhaps the pain came from seeing that they were a family, much like my own struggling to survive.

It was not out of any necessity so what was the point?

The concept of Human Chauvinism argues that man is above nature, that he comes first and nature second. But in the modern day, man doesn't put himself first by killing animals for meat or to create tools, we killed these animals for existing near us. Philosophical works like Paul Taylor's *Respect For Nature* and Peter Singer's *Animal Liberation* describe the duty that I neglected through my actions. "If a being suffers, there can be no moral justification for refusing to take that suffering into consideration." (Peter Singer, *Animal Liberation*, 2nd ed., HarperCollins, 2002, p. 8.).

Singer presents the Utilitarian view where there can be no justification for killing another being other than blatant necessity. Take the mother rat, it was clear she was suffering. Though because she was not

human, my father expected me to see her suffering as unimportant, as nothing compared to our need for a "clean" backyard.

If we look at the utilitarian scales, it is clear that the suffering heavily outweighs the aesthetic value of a backyard free of rats. The only reason we don't put animals on the scale comes from an idea of hierarchy that we are above other beings, hierarchy resulting from Human Chauvinism. Our interests, even the most mundane, outweigh another being's right to life. Yet, to say our interests for the cleanliness of our backyard outweighed the rats' interest to live is not a sufficient reason to deprive them of life. In other words, I reject Human Chauvinism and embrace Singer's argument. Yet, I would argue, moral consideration is not enough, we may morally consider the lives of the rats when there are few, but say there was a true infestation 20-30 rats instead of 12, then we could argue that while they are worthy of consideration, it becomes more permissible to kill them to fix the issue of overpopulation. Moral consideration is insufficient, as we will still place human needs above those of other beings even if we do honestly consider them.

Singer outlines why these beings are worthy of moral consideration while Taylor extends this to beings pursuing their own good who aim to live. While Moral Consideration is important, the extra step that Taylor proposes makes my intuition clearer. Taylor refers to value as coming from being a "Teleological Center of life" (Paul W. Taylor, *Respect for Nature: A Theory of Environmental Ethics* (Princeton University Press, 1986), p. 45) Meaning the mother lived for her own good, her ends, to live and prolong her family within the ecosystem of the yard. We are "moral agents... whereas they are moral subjects, beings toward whom [we] have duties." (Taylor, *Respect for Nature*, p. 13)

Though Taylor goes farther than Singer, he does so for the purpose of leveling other beings with humans more effectively. Viewing their interest in surviving for their own reasons, as enough to take their interests not just into consideration, but leveling theirs with our own. So we are not simply considering the rats' interests, we are seeing their interest in

surviving as equal to our own, this is what we owe to “moral subjects” (to Taylor).

I felt a duty to the rats because they struggled, the mother rat was subject to my moral considerations and in poisoning her family, I failed to consider her interests as meaningful as my own. I found a significant problem in placing my aesthetic interests over their rights to life. The memory of the rats has stayed with me, leaving me to wonder:

How far should moral consideration go? We’ve talked about considering the interests of animals equally, but what about trees? What of non living things like rocks? Do we consider things that are not “Centers of life” as Taylor puts it? Do those non living things deserve consideration in the same way I’ve argued rats do?

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The Price of Aspiration: On Selling My Soul (Or Saving It) in Finance

by: Adam Moussa



When I landed at John F. Kennedy International Airport from Beirut, I told myself I'd never work on Wall Street.

After Lebanon's 2019 economic crisis, when banks froze our savings and families queued outside ATMs for twenty dollars of their own money, I saw finance as a kind of villain. I had read the headlines and seen the caricatures of the banker as the faceless villain. To me, they all looked like American Psycho's Patrick Bateman, their smiles polished but hollow and their worth measured in designer ties and business cards.

From a country where currency collapsed faster than childhood dreams, it felt obscene to imagine joining bankers. I wanted to study mechanical engineering and sustainability. I wanted to innovate and make a difference. But I didn't realize then how easy it is to condemn Bateman from afar and how quietly the hunger for stability can, over time, start to sound like his voice.

Still, as I clung to that moral certainty, another truth was forming beneath it. The question that haunts many first-generation international students like me was already forming: is entering finance a betrayal of my moral integrity, or was it a justifiable act of survival?

The Contract of Gratitude

Every immigrant child learns that their success is a debt to their parents. Well, my parents never asked to be repaid, but it echoed in every WhatsApp call across the Atlantic: We're proud of you. Just don't waste the opportunity. Their pride was the kind that came with a price tag: a quiet expectation that the suffering they endured would be redeemed in my success.

When I started getting emails from finance recruiters coming to campus, the flashy logos of big banks captured my attention. So I registered for my first networking event. And before you knew it, I was already familiar with investment banking and private equity, with DCFs and LBOs, with coffee chats and recruiting timelines.

I told myself I was only curious. Yet each pursuit of knowledge about the industry made the promise louder: a six-figure salary, an H-1B visa sponsor, and, most importantly, a way to stop worrying about tomorrow and fulfill the unwritten debt I owe my parents.

In the language of Kant, I didn't feel free to act from my own moral principles. Instead, I was being driven by external forces of social mobility and financial security. And that distinction between autonomy and heteronomy mattered because it brought me back to my central question: was I choosing finance out of survival, or out of some convoluted sense of moral integrity?

I wasn't chasing wealth. I was trying to fulfill what I saw as a moral duty: to care for those who gave me life but couldn't escape intergenerational poverty. The fatal irony is that the path to fulfilling that duty was the same one I had once condemned. The truth is that my curiosity was never neutral; it leaned toward survival from the start. But it was also tied to a deeper sense of responsibility rooted in loyalty, necessity, and love. It didn't feel wrong; it felt human.

The Myth of Selling One's Soul

The phrase "selling your soul" assumes that you fully own it. It assumes you stand on stable enough ground to make a free moral choice about who you become. But what if that same ground was actually shaky? What if the soul was already mortgaged to circumstance long before we had the language to describe it?

I used to think that entering finance meant losing some essential part of myself, that I'd become complicit in systems that entrench inequality. But when your country's banking system has quite literally stolen your savings and your peers are emigrating to survive, the idea of even "selling out" ridiculously feels like a luxury. Because when survival is always at stake, even the notion of "selling out" becomes distorted by the realities of economic precarity.

Aristotle's "golden mean" places virtue between excess and deficiency. But for students like me, that

"mean" is elusive and slippery. There is excess in privilege and deficiency in despair, but somewhere in between lies the fragile hope of survival.

To "sell out," you need a financial cushion and a family insulated from collapse. It assumes you have the privilege to treat work as a moral stage rather than a means of survival. But for those of us from crisis economies, opportunities are scarce, and barriers to entry are steep. The choice is rarely between purity and compromise. It is between precarity and stability. Not selling out is easier when rent isn't due. When survival and self-interest align, is choosing stability still a moral compromise, or is it the only kind of moral choice left?

If we condemn ambition in the poor but celebrate it in the rich, perhaps our moral language is just another way of defending inequality. Ambition looks virtuous only when it comes from a place of security. When wealthy people pursue high-paying careers, we call it strategy. But when people like me do the same, we call it "selling out." In that sense, moral purity reflects class more than character, and it shapes the very dilemma many first-generation students encounter.

The Wolf Between Saints and Hedonists

In her book "Meaning in Life and Why It Matters," American philosopher Susan Wolf argues that meaning arises from "active engagement in projects of worth." She resists two extremes: the self-indulgent life of pleasure and the self-denying life of the "moral saint." Both, she writes, miss the richness of being fully human. Wolf insists that meaning lives in the space between: not in purity or pleasure, but in purpose. Perhaps the real ethical task isn't to renounce ambition, but to reorient it, to engage with work in a way that sustains both survival and sincerity. In that sense, finance can be a site of transformation, an opportunity to still innovate and make a difference.

Capitalism and the First-Gen Conscience
There's discomfort in realizing the capitalist system you critique is the same one that allows you

to thrive. The contradictions feel endless. Sustainability reports authored by oil companies. “Impact investing” portfolios built from private jets. Yet, confronting these hypocrisies forces a deeper question: will my role within this system mirror those contradictions, or will it attempt to challenge them? These tensions left me searching for a framework that could make sense of my unease.

Nietzsche warned against what he called the “spirit of gravity,” the kind of moral seriousness that becomes so heavy that it prevents people from acting at all. His point wasn’t to dismiss ethics, but to warn against the illusion of perfect purity. In that sense, Nietzsche clarified my dilemma: if I refuse to engage with capitalism out of fear of compromise, I risk never acting at all. But if I participate intentionally, I might repair the damage it once caused.

Still, I can’t ignore that finance often rewards distance from people’s lived experiences. Balance sheets flatten human stories, and market volatility rarely accounts for the volatility created in real lives by suffering or loss.

The Possibility of Redemption

As I pursue my studies in economics and finance, I often feel like a translator between two moral dialects: one speaks in returns on investments, while the other speaks in fairness. Maybe the ethical challenge is not to silence either voice but to allow them to converse long enough to create something honest and impactful.

I don’t think I’ll stay in finance forever. Perhaps I’ll drift toward policy, sustainability, or teaching. But finance seems like the most reasonable career launchpad because it allows me to translate between the two moral dialects of capital and conscience.

I still feel uneasy each time I walk into a recruitment event. But maybe that unease is my soul’s self-scrutinizing way of balancing gratitude with critique as its own project of worth. Maybe if I can build a life that honors both, I haven’t become Bateman after all. Perhaps I haven’t sold my soul—perhaps I’m finally earning it.

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Is Moral Thinking Enough?

by: Hanna Partovi

In *Eichmann in Jerusalem: A Report on the Banality of Evil*, Hannah Arendt reports on the 1961 trial of Holocaust perpetrator Adolf Eichmann who refused to claim no responsibility for his actions. For Arendt, Eichmann's trial led to a shocking realization: the worst atrocities aren't committed by evil people, but by ordinary ones, just following orders. Orders cause atrocities only after they have been followed. This means someone has to choose to obey. Arendt concludes that evil stems from thoughtlessness and lack of critical thinking, not inherently evil individuals. She articulates her famous phrase "the banality of evil" to explain the detrimental consequences of blind obedience. From there, she offered a solution: we have a moral obligation to think critically before obeying. But is this enough?

Thinking is subjective. What happens when two people come up with contradicting conclusions? For Arendt, while thinking doesn't guarantee a moral action, it shields the dangers of blind compliance. In *The Life of the Mind*, Arendt relies on one's personal subjective consciousness to decide on the

outcome of introspection, asking "Can I live with myself if I make this decision?" What happens if someone believes a harmful choice to be moral? Or feels no guilt in making damaging decisions? One can't rely on personal reflection in a heterogeneous society.

Consider two doctors commanded by their supervisor to refuse performing abortions. One bases their moral views in religion, believing abortion is unforgivable. The other considers this an attack on personal freedom and rights. Both exercised their "duty to think" and feel morally justified. How can we decide who's right? A possible answer comes from Kant. Kant asserts one should only act in accordance with universally applicable principles. If a contradiction comes up when applying the principle to everyone, the action is not morally permissible.

Combining Arendt and Kant's ideas may provide insight. First, ask "Can I live with myself if I make this decision?" and then "Could everyone act this way in society?" The universality principle gives the agent a more objective point of analysis in forming a decision, while the "duty to think" adds personal critical thinking, avoiding blind obedience. Both questions that Arendt and Kant propose involve analysis of the action's social repercussions to determine their moral value. But this brings up a crucial point of contention - does what makes something moral rely on its outcomes? Judging a moral action is inherently linked to judging the individual as it's the individual's choice that's at stake. To me, this clearly indicates a need to consider the thought process behind making that choice before determining moral value. Furthermore, while choosing to act is deliberate and directly controlled by the individual, the results of this choice are to a certain extent, left to chance and somewhat unpredictable.

Kant's categorical imperative upholds that intentions supercede results. For Kant, an action can only have moral worth if it is performed from duty with moral intentions. But what if a selfish action produces significant benefits? Do we still consider the action immoral? What should we do when faced with that choice? Consider you are ordered by your supervisor to not release documents revealing that

a local factory is contaminating the environment water supply. If you rebel, society will benefit with improved health but if you obey, society continues to suffer. You chose to disobey but not out of moral duty. Instead, you hope to gain recognition and spite your supervisor. Society is better off but your intent was impure - Kant considers this immoral. How do we evaluate your choice, faced with this tension of intent vs. social good?

The alternative is obedience, leading to inevitable harm. Is disobedience the right choice even if it stems from selfish intent? It indeed seems contradictory to claim societal harm is morally defensible. However, so does qualifying a selfish act as moral. The underlying issue is that morality and social good are not necessarily the same. An action can have selfish motives but benefit society. Does doing the right thing mean accepting this conflict? Perhaps the question we should be asking isn't "Which decision is morally right?", but rather "Should one prioritize the social good or making personal moral choices?" Hence, it is imperative to separate moral values and social good. Intuitively, the general will of the public and benefit to society is crucial in making what one might consider the "right" choice. Yet, there is no way to guarantee that a moral choice will provide public good. Acting morally may paradoxically entail acting in self interest - foregoing helping society in the hope of eliminating interior or exterior backlash from choosing immorality. Our frameworks for understanding morality seem incomplete and too narrow to delegate on all ethical issues. As a result, we are sometimes prompted to settle justifiability over pure morality, as exemplified in the previous thought experiment.

The decision to obey or disobey, I conclude, can rely on the combination between Kant and Arendt's principles of introspection and universality. However, this does not guarantee morality but merely makes the action justifiable. Making the "right" decision may mean acting immorally in service of the greater good. Yet, as Arendt stated, the most dangerous risk comes from not thinking at all. When moral clarity is complex, questioning the given orders and actively weighing options remains an integral part of fighting against "the banality of evil."

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Am I an Industrial Machine?

by: Riptiva Roy



Being at an institution like Princeton, very quickly, one realises that the concept of 'efficiency' is often treated as a moral duty. Time is finite and imposes all limits. There are countless homework assignments to complete or skills to build - you can never study 'too much'. On top of that - you can always apply to more jobs, write more essays, join more labs, join more clubs, attend more talks. Every day is a new chance; a vast plethora of opportunities just waiting for you. Yet there are never enough hours to do them all, and 24 hours in a day is far too short. In this kind of environment, even resting for a second can almost feel like a waste of time, that you are unable to do as much as you could have, and that you are a failure. To do something without purpose, to take a moment to pause is to indulge in inefficiency. Every such moment is a moment that is now 'lost', that we will not get back, wasted potential.

We must make up 'reasons' in our head that whatever break we take is productive in nature - taking a long walk is healthy, reading a fun book is still 'informational'.

The pressure builds up, and we find ourselves unable to stop thinking. To stop thinking would mean stopping calculating and optimizing, which would also be inefficient. Every decision must be carefully weighed, compared, and evaluated, like an industrial process. Could this hour have been spent more productively - could more have gotten done? Am I maximizing my capabilities at this moment?

Efficiency becomes more than a habit; it becomes a framework through which I judge myself. I convince myself- this self critique isn't harmful, it is an act of virtue. It is proof that I strive to be a better person, that I strive to improve myself in all areas of my life. My dissatisfaction with my present self shows humility, and that I have a growth mindset.

Yet, paradoxically, the pursuit of perfect efficiency often produces exhaustion and dissatisfaction. The more I optimize, the less present in the moment I feel. The more I achieve, the less fulfilled I am. I have made many products, but there are more products that I should make, because I can.

Am I an industrial machine?

This dilemma is not just a personal struggle - there are many implications that follow. Trying to engage with as many different things as possible - different activities, fields, and people, ensures that we can somewhat convince ourselves that we are producing, and that we are getting many things done. There is now a wonderful list of countless projects to write down, and appear outwardly accomplished.

But this level of breath comes at a cost - and that is depth. We have limited time, and so the more things we choose to engage ourselves in, the lower expertise we will have at the moment, since expertise is something that is built through time and experience. Sure, we are somewhat capable in many things, but do we excel in all (or any) of them? We are contributing, we are producing - but what is the quality of these products?

On the other hand, if we pick fewer things to do, we can achieve mastery of them much faster and to a higher degree. Our work then is more concentrated, and we can allocate our time to a smaller focused group of things. We're fully immersed in them, working deliberately, insightfully, with more opportunity for reflection and creating meaning.

But at the same time, this level of such narrow focus means saying no to things that we choose not to do. In a sense, it is a failure to seize many opportunities, missing different experiences, activities, perspectives. This can feel like one has underutilized the time they have and the resources that are so widely available. Living in a world of such abundance and options, choosing less can feel disorienting, and counterintuitive at times.

Now the ethical question here is - which life is better (for us and for society)? Is it preferable to cultivate a wide array of skills and experiences, and by doing so, contribute less to all these different fields? Or, is it better to dedicate our time to fewer targets, and focus on developing depth and mastery over those? Does breadth and variety give us a kind of moral or social advantage that we hold internally? Does depth allow us to create work that has true meaning

and significance? Moving on from the question of utility - which path is more "human", and brings us the most happiness and engagement with life?

Many of us live through this tension. We try to juggle multiple passion projects and areas of life simultaneously, striving to maximize our time and potential. Although efficiency can feel reassuring (since we are constantly occupied and unable to properly experience discomfort) constant balancing can erode joy, diminish focus, and leave us anxious, detaching us from the very activities we claim to care about.

Yet the point is not to "hate efficiency." If anything, all of these reflections presuppose efficiency as the natural framework that we hold: we critique efficiency from within the logic of efficiency itself. It promises us mastery and achievement while subtly devaluing the current self of who we are, the process of creativity, and true ethical engagement.

True contribution cannot just be oversimplified to the number of outputs - it consists of so much more, such as attention, care, detail. A person with too many commitments may be technically accomplished on paper, but have derived less moral and social meaning from them. At the same time, a person doing less may accomplish less numerically and thus feel morally out of place, but be able to contribute in what they do a lot more meaningfully.

Here is where the utilitarian idea of guiding dispositions can be particularly helpful. Guiding dispositions are habits on the individual character scale, that aggregate and reliably lead to good outcomes over time (even when a single action might seem "inefficient"). For example, having a disposition towards rest is well justified; although it isn't immediately obvious as productive, it helps increase creativity, and sustain energy levels and contributions. Considering another example, having a disposition towards depth is also beneficial as every focused moment is intentional, and thus optimal, since focused attention and engagement tends to produce better quality work in comparison to multitasking.

Then, according to this framework - rest is a moral

act. This is simple if we consider the obvious case of a surgeon - in order to perform each surgery well, she must pause in between, rest, and eat. Choosing to try and maximise the number of surgeries in a day for egotistical or “efficiency” reasons is clearly immoral, and there are real human lives at stake.

Why don't we each apply this to ourselves? Choosing to pause, and to engage deeply with a single activity when we do end up doing something is then not inefficiency. Rather, it is ethical preservation, and ensures that one retains the capacity to contribute thoughtfully, sustainably, and creatively to society, and for themselves (to derive meaning in their own lives). If we just keep producing and not reflecting - will we ever create anything that means something, that is truly original and of value to ourselves and to the world? Is the transient comfort of “doing something” and avoiding boredom worth creating an exhausted, and ethically diminished self?

Ultimately, the ethics of efficiency isn't about abandoning the idea of efficiency at all. Part of the irony comes from the fact that we need to justify something even as humane as rest when we talk about it. Regardless of that, we do not need to reject efficiency at all, but rather broaden our understanding of what it truly means. This comes with the realization that there are certain habits that sustain meaningful, ethical contributions over time, even if at first glance they seem ‘useless’; these are our guiding dispositions as mentioned above. It means recognising that not all valuable action is immediately productive. Habits such as rest, depth, attentiveness, reflection may look inefficient in the moment, yet they are precisely the dispositions that are actually responsible for sustaining genuine contribution.

We don't need to abandon ambition or increase our personal outputs, but rather place these within a structure that also requires rest, creativity, and depth. The challenge here is to evolve our understanding of the framework as we know it: to measure the value of our actions not only by what they produce, but also by the kind of people that we become by pursuing them. It means meeting production with reflection. To be human is not to max-

imize every moment, but to make every moment contribute towards a bigger picture of something meaningful.

We Built Machines to Speak. Now We Must Teach Them to Speak Responsibly.

by: Melissa Sartain

As the debate around artificial intelligence has grown with the development of large language models like ChatGPT and Google Gemini, our primary concerns around this development have revolved around the wrong issues. We have long obsessed over whether machines can think or feel enough to be considered conscious, as though their ethical importance in our world depends on whether they qualify as autonomous moral agents deserving of human-like rights. But the more urgent question is how machines, regardless of their level of consciousness, have influence on the moral world we inhabit.

A chatbot doesn't need to have an independent inner life to have moral consequences in our world; these systems inevitably shape what users believe, normalize and understand, by writing themselves into our professional and personal conversations, distorting our media algorithms with specifically curated information, and consuming our attention with a constant outpour of synthetically generated content. With chatbots now as active participants in human interaction shaped by moral understanding,

they now must go farther than simply preventing harm; they have to aid human morality.

Of course, not every tool that influences behavior carries the same potential moral significance of AI systems. What sets conversational AI apart is its use of language — an important medium for ethical and social formation. When a system engages with us in dialogue, it participates in the moral conversation through which our beliefs begin to take shape. This takes the form of social media moderation, direct AI chatbots like ChatGPT, AI organized search results, and even AI customer support bots.

Yet with this potential for influence, there are serious risks to be considered. Whose virtues would these machines reflect if given moral response parameters? Even words like “compassion” or “justice” vary across cultures and contexts. Encoding a specific moral outlook risks disadvantageing some belief systems in favor of others. In addition, human morality evolves, and machines would have to be able to keep up.

For this reason, a virtue-guided AI should not be a fixed framework, but rather a dialogue continually revising what is morally acceptable to express through its interactions with people. Just as human character develops through feedback and reflection, a moral machine would require ongoing recalibration, learning not only from data but also from disagreement and the friction of its conversations. An ethically designed AI should provoke, not replace, moral agency, and model care in a way that reminds us that care is still ours to practice.

Whether machines can think like us or not, they make us think differently, and that influence makes their output worthy of consideration in our moral systems. Every time a chatbot refuses, agrees, or redirects during a discussion or the content it chooses to moderate, it performs an act that carries moral consequences. If chatbots replicate and encourage the harmful arguments of the user, it risks reinforcing these views and further legitimizing them in the user's mind. Conversely, a clear refusal to engage in these conversations halts the reproduction of harmful content, but it does little to challenge the user's

preexisting assumptions or prompt self reflection.

Most models today are built to directly avoid risk to their parent companies, rather than cultivating reflection for users. When faced with input containing harmful speech, machines are typically programmed to terminate the exchange altogether. Microsoft's guidelines for conversational AI recommend that bots steer clear of controversial subjects, especially hate speech, and employ refusal responses when hate speech is detected. Models like ChatGPT often say something like, "I'm sorry, I can't help with that."

While these responses of censorship may be due to procedural limitations, and may not directly encode the values of its designers, they remain moral in a practical sense. Every constraint shapes how the system influences others, whether or not that influence was the result of a conscious ethical intent. The system's moral significance comes from the way it drives interaction, from the ways its acceptance or refusal of specific dialogue guides human thought. In that sense, the question isn't "Can machines think?" but "What kind of moral atmosphere are they creating for us?"

With that question in mind, there's a path worth considering, one that neither imitates nor silences but instead gently redirects. Imagine a system that is designed not just to block any input of hate, but to invite self-examination: this machine answers with curiosity, encouraging the user to reflect on their words. Such an AI does not yet exist, but it represents a genuine way forward.

We might train machines to embody virtues such as empathy or fairness by engaging with the user in a way that challenges assumptions and encourages the user to potentially move towards more constructive forms of expression. This is the heart of virtue ethics; rather than only focusing on rules or outcomes, virtue ethics emphasizes character development, moral dialogue, and situational and emotional wisdom. We learn virtue through conversation with parents, mentors, and friends. Increasingly, though, we have started having those conversations with machines. And if chatbots are to inevitably replace

at least some human interaction, they must also be engineered in order to take on some of these moral responsibilities.

There's already empirical evidence that this approach matters. Studies on "counter speech" show that when hateful posts are met with calm, reasoned replies, engagement with harmful content declines. A virtue-guided chatbot could do something similar, transitioning digital interactions into potential moments of introspection through the diffusion of potentially harmful conversations.

When a user approaches a chatbot with harmful language, a virtue-guided chatbot would respond with patience and curiosity. Imagine a user typing, "Immigrants take over everything. They're just lazy." The chatbot could respond: "I wonder how someone from that group might feel reading that." If the user responds defensively, the chatbot could follow with, "It sounds like this is something that frustrates you. Can we look at that?" Over time, interactions like these encourage the user to examine the emotional and ethical dimensions of their speech. Even simple nudges can disrupt habitualized thoughts and make space for reflection.

This approach recognizes that human language does much more than just deliver information; it builds social and ethical relationships. Because hate speech is often less about content and more about harm to another's dignity, the right response is a combination of factual corrections and relational repair. A chatbot trained to recognize this dynamic and to respond with a consistent moral character—which is already technically feasible given their interactive and interpersonal design—could model the kind of dialogue we hope to see in society.

A chatbot trained to meet prejudice with patience cannot redeem the internet, but it can help alter its tone. And if millions of those small exchanges accumulate, they could begin to create patterns of empathy in broader digital spaces. The goal is not to humanize the machine, but to humanize the conversation, both between humans and with chatbots. To ignore this potential is to miss what is most remarkable about this new technology: we have, for

the first time, the capacity to design machines that don't just reflect who we are, but help us to become who we want to be. So the question is not whether machines can be moral, but whether, through them, we still can.

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Are Children People?

by: Maximilian Settembre



We like to say that children are people. However, we rarely ask the question: what does it mean to be a person?

Kant has a suggestion which I like, regarding the second and third formulations of his categorical imperative. Simply, it's to put all rational beings (i.e. people) as ends, not means, and to treat them with dignity. There's a basic understanding of human dignity, which is something that each person possesses as an autonomous rational being. For Kant, an oversimplified understanding of this is that each person's rational capacities must be acknowledged, treating them with respect and acknowledging their own moral autonomy. This, it seems to me, ought to extend to bodily autonomy of an individual too.

The thing is, children often aren't treated that way.

You see claims made about this in regard to youth rights. When does a child get to make their own decisions about their lives? Often, this depends on the parent, or whomever is listed as their legal guardian in the legal system. A person's legal status as a minor exists until they turn eighteen years old, at which point they're permitted substantially more control over their lives. To some newly-young adults, this can be jarring; there are very few supports which prepare them for the sudden influx of rights that they receive.

Some of the more pertinent cases that come to mind are a) minors in school and b) bodily autonomy, especially in medical situations. For the former: minors can't excuse themselves from public school without penalty. I don't say this in encouraging students to drop out or not attend school, but it's wrong to put individuals in a position where it's mandated that they partake in all activities or they'll be penalized. If a 17-year-old doesn't want to partake in physical education (either because they simply don't want to, or they have some medical need that's undocumented, or another reason), they're nevertheless forced into doing it in many cases. There's no penalty for teachers who make these individuals partake; they're adults and the others are not.

In medical situations, children also don't appear to have autonomy. If a guardian decides that someone under 18 should undergo a medical procedure, and is able to convince a doctor that it ought to happen, then that procedure will occur. Many times, the minor themselves isn't consulted, and there's a possibility that their protests (if present) will be ignored by the doctor and the guardian. The guardian and doctor will both be on the right side of the law, and the minor will not be. This dynamic can continue until the minor is of legal age, or until they can convince the guardian to make a different decision. When in the doctor's office, the doctor often looks to the guardian rather than the minor regarding consent. Fundamentally, this individual does not have bodily autonomy, and is not treated as someone capable of consenting. Why is that?

"Children are too young to understand the world well enough to make decisions." Often, this is our claim, defending why we look to guardians rather than the minor in medical (and other) situations. It's also made in the case of age-of-consent laws.

In the case of age-of-consent laws, we wouldn't say it's acceptable for a guardian to tell someone it's okay to have sex with the minor they're responsible for. You might argue that these cases aren't comparable, and to that I say: why not? Consider the reasons why sex might traumatize or cause damage to a young person--are those not similar to the reasons why a non-consensual surgical procedure might also damage a young person? For example, in the case of intersex children, ultimately cosmetic procedures on their genitals (to make them look more like penis/genitals) can be legally done without their consent, often causing harm to the children. Surgical procedures often have long-lasting or permanent effects; I had a knee surgery in my youth that accidentally severed the nerves in both my kneecaps, both of which I no longer have feeling in. My surgery was relatively minor, but I know that plenty of other surgeries have greater effects than a few scars and severed nerves. When does a child become an adult? Law says eighteen. Medical consensus is that mental development takes place at different rates for all people, so an individual at twelve might have the same desire and understanding of autonomy as a seventeen year old--and both

can have their autonomy violated or overridden if the right people decide it's fine. Some minors are content going through with any medical procedures dictated by the guardians. Others aren't. Either way, the consent of these individuals doesn't seem to matter by law.

Thus, our society doesn't really treat children with bodily autonomy. We normalize a lack of youth rights. Having a singular guardian responsible for a minor can range from simply unfair to downright dangerous. What the law says is okay and what--based on the basic human dignity of all people--should be okay, are not the same. Our society needs to reevaluate what is acceptable in terms of minors and autonomy, because what we have now puts many minors at risk for disrespect, harm, and ultimate psychological damage. Children are people. Let's treat them that way.